



Metropolitan Water Reclamation District of Greater Chicago

2026 MWRD: Respect, Civility & Inclusion Training

Employee Edition

This training is designed to help employees understand their role in creating a respectful, civil, and inclusive workplace. During this session, we will discuss workplace expectations, appropriate conduct, employee responsibilities, and what to do if you experience or witness behavior that does not align with District policy.

Presented By:

[Facilitator Name]



Agenda

1

Welcome & Employee Role

Training overview | Your role in workplace culture

2

Harassment, Discrimination & Retaliation

Policy definitions | Intent vs. impact | Video case study

3

Respectful Workplace, Civility & Inclusion

Respect in practice | Behavioral gap | Spectrum Sort activity



BREAK—10 min

4

Reporting Concerns & Employee Responsibilities

When to report | Reporting options | Role play activity

5

Reflection

Personal commitment

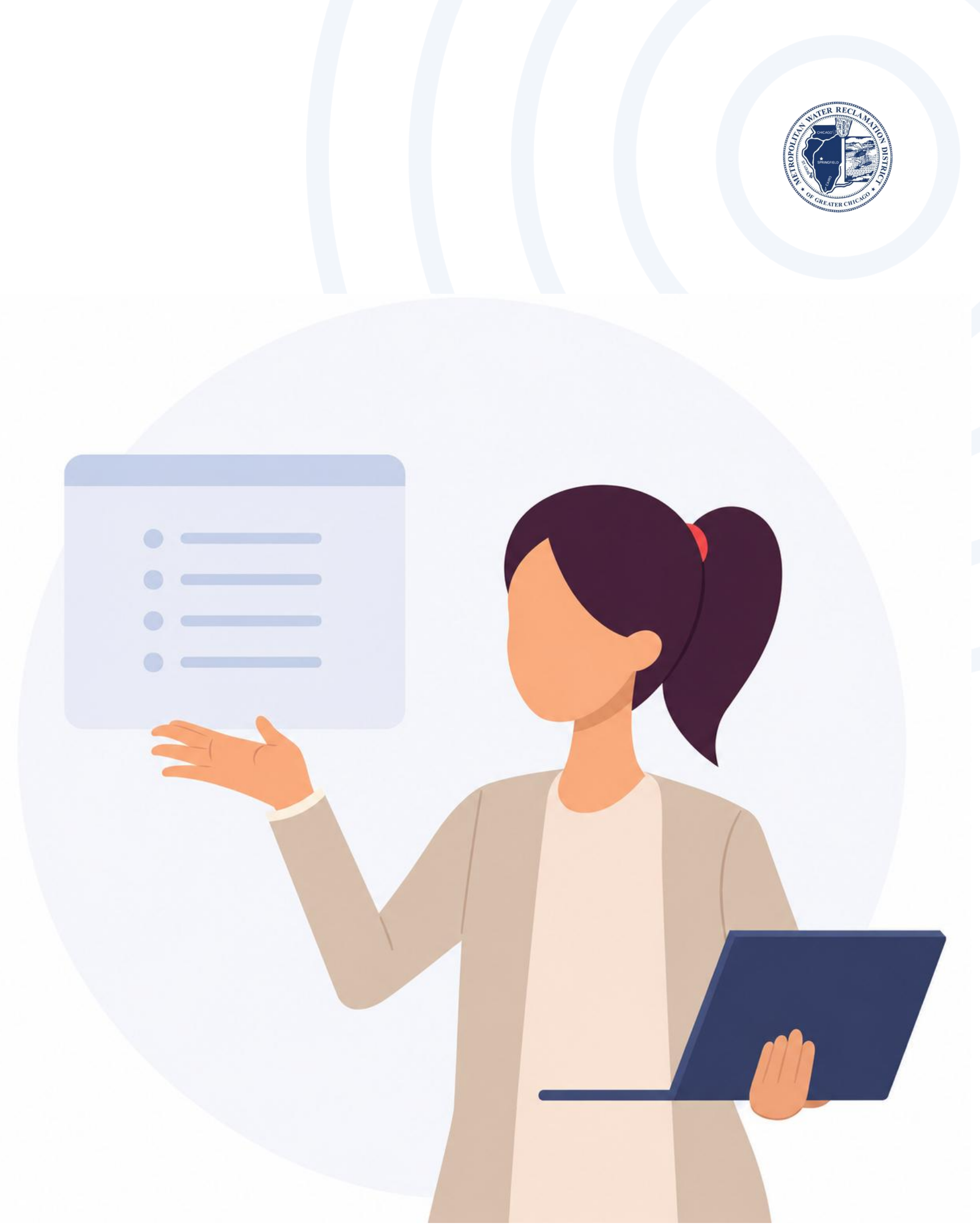




Training Objectives

By the end of this session, you will be able to:

- ✓ Recognize inappropriate workplace behavior
- ✓ Understand employee rights and responsibilities
- ✓ Respond appropriately to workplace concerns
- ✓ Identify when and how to report concerns
- ✓ Contribute to a respectful workplace



Why This Matters To You

This training matters because workplace behavior affects everyone. The way we communicate, treat others, and respond to concerns impacts workplace culture, employee safety, teamwork, and the District's work environment.



Your Protection

Know your rights and how to use them



Your Team

Behavior affects everyone around you



Early Intervention

Small issues become big problems when ignored



Your Voice

Reporting is expected

Activity 1

What Does Respect Look Like?

Reflect on a time you felt respected by a colleague or leader.

- What actions led to that feeling?
- How did it influence your performance?

Now, consider the opposite.

- What does a disrespectful workplace feel like?
- What is the cost of that culture?





Your Role in a Respectful Workplace

Workplace culture is shaped by every employee, every day.



Your actions



Your words



What you
allow



What you
report



How you
treat people



AP 10.5.0
Anti-Harassment,
Anti-Discrimination



AP 10.27.0
Rules for
Employee Conduct



Module 2

Harassment, Discrimination & Retaliation

What is Harassment?

Harassment is any unwelcome conduct based on a legally protected characteristic that either:

- Becomes a condition of continued employment, or
- Is severe or pervasive enough to create an intimidating, hostile, or offensive work environment.



IMPORTANT

Harassment does not require physical contact. It includes verbal, written, and visual conduct. Intent is not required. Impact is the standard.



Legally Protected Characteristics

- Race, color, sex, gender
- Religion, age, national origin or ethnicity
- Sexual orientation, gender identity
- Disability
- Genetic information
- Pregnancy-related conditions
- Veteran or military status
- *Association with anyone having these characteristics.*

Sexual Harassment Defined

Quid Pro Quo

Submission to sexual conduct is made a condition of employment, or rejection is used as the basis for an employment decision.

Hostile Work Environment

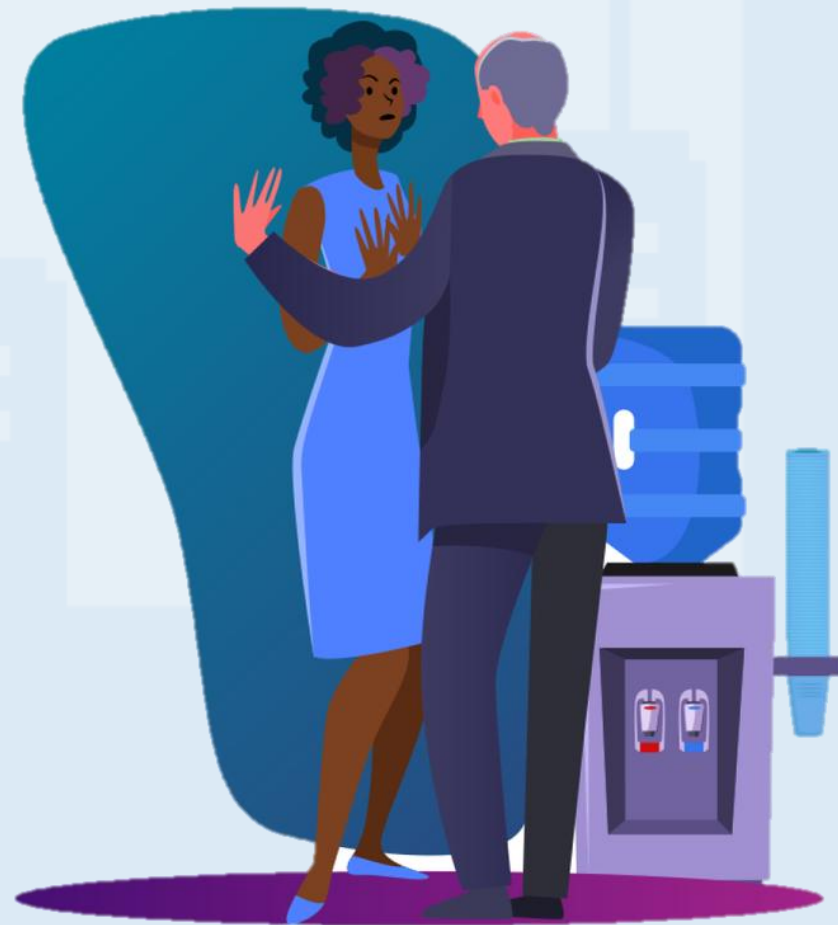
Conduct unreasonably interferes with work performance or creates an intimidating, hostile, or offensive environment.

The Legal Standard

Unwelcome is the test — not whether someone objected, laughed, or said nothing. Off-site and off-hours conduct is covered when it affects the employment relationship.



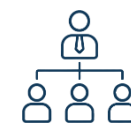
Quid Pro Quo Harassment



Quid pro quo means "this for that." It occurs when someone in a position of authority offers or implies a workplace benefit in exchange for personal or romantic favors or threatens negative consequences for refusing.

➔ **ONE**

incident is sufficient to constitute a violation



Requires a power imbalance: supervisor, manager, or person with authority



The offer or threat may be **explicit or implied**



Does not require the employee to comply for a violation to occur



Examples: promotions, favorable shifts, positive evaluations, or discipline tied to personal favors

Report Immediately: 312-751-4443



What is Discrimination?

Discrimination is the unjust or unequal treatment of individuals or groups based on legally or socially protected characteristics such as race, color, sex, age, religion, disability, sexual orientation, gender identity, national origin, or any protected characteristic.



Different treatment in terms or conditions of employment based on a protected characteristic



Decisions based on stereotypes about abilities or performance

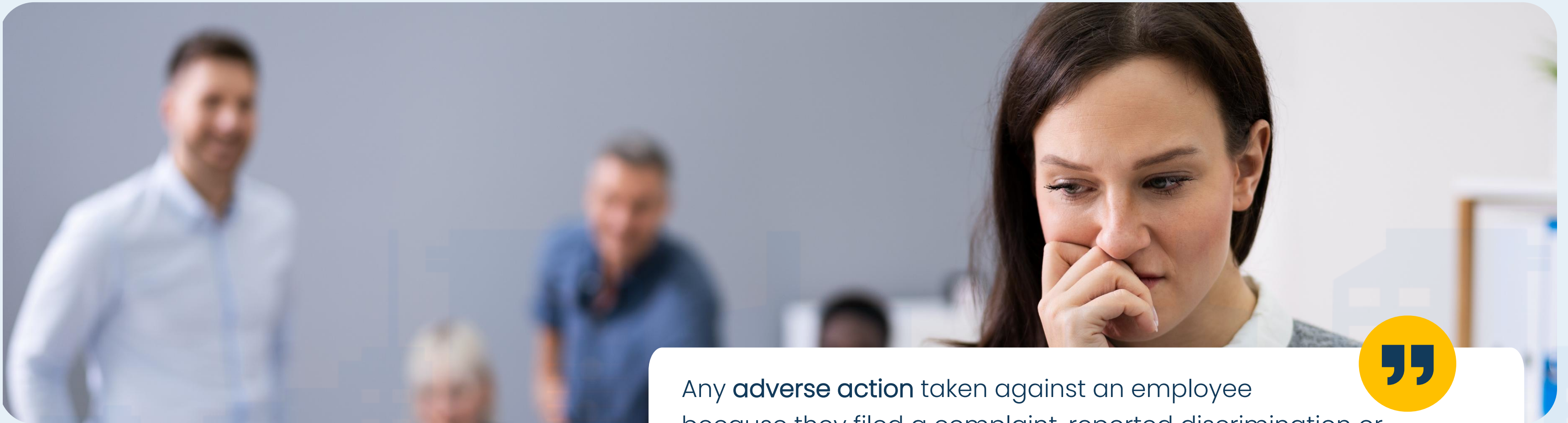


Intentional or unintentional discrimination



AP 10.5.0
Anti-Harassment,
Anti-Discrimination





Any **adverse action** taken against an employee because they filed a complaint, reported discrimination or harassment, participated in an investigation, or opposed discriminatory conduct.



Recognizing Possible Retaliation

- ☐ Being excluded from meetings or projects
- ☐ Sudden negative treatment after reporting concerns
- ☐ Increased scrutiny or criticism
- ☐ Changes in communication or workplace behavior
- ☐ Loss of opportunities or responsibilities

What is Retaliation?

Intent vs. Impact

The intent of the person engaging in conduct does not determine whether a violation occurred. What matters is the impact on the person experiencing it and whether a reasonable person would find the environment intimidating, hostile, or offensive.



INTENT

What I meant
Invisible to others

- Well-intended behavior can still create a hostile environment.
- The reasonable person standard: would most people find this offensive.



IMPACT

What was experienced
Visible | Observable

- "I didn't mean it that way" is not a defense under AP 10.5.0
- Good intent is a mitigating factor in discipline, not a defense against violation

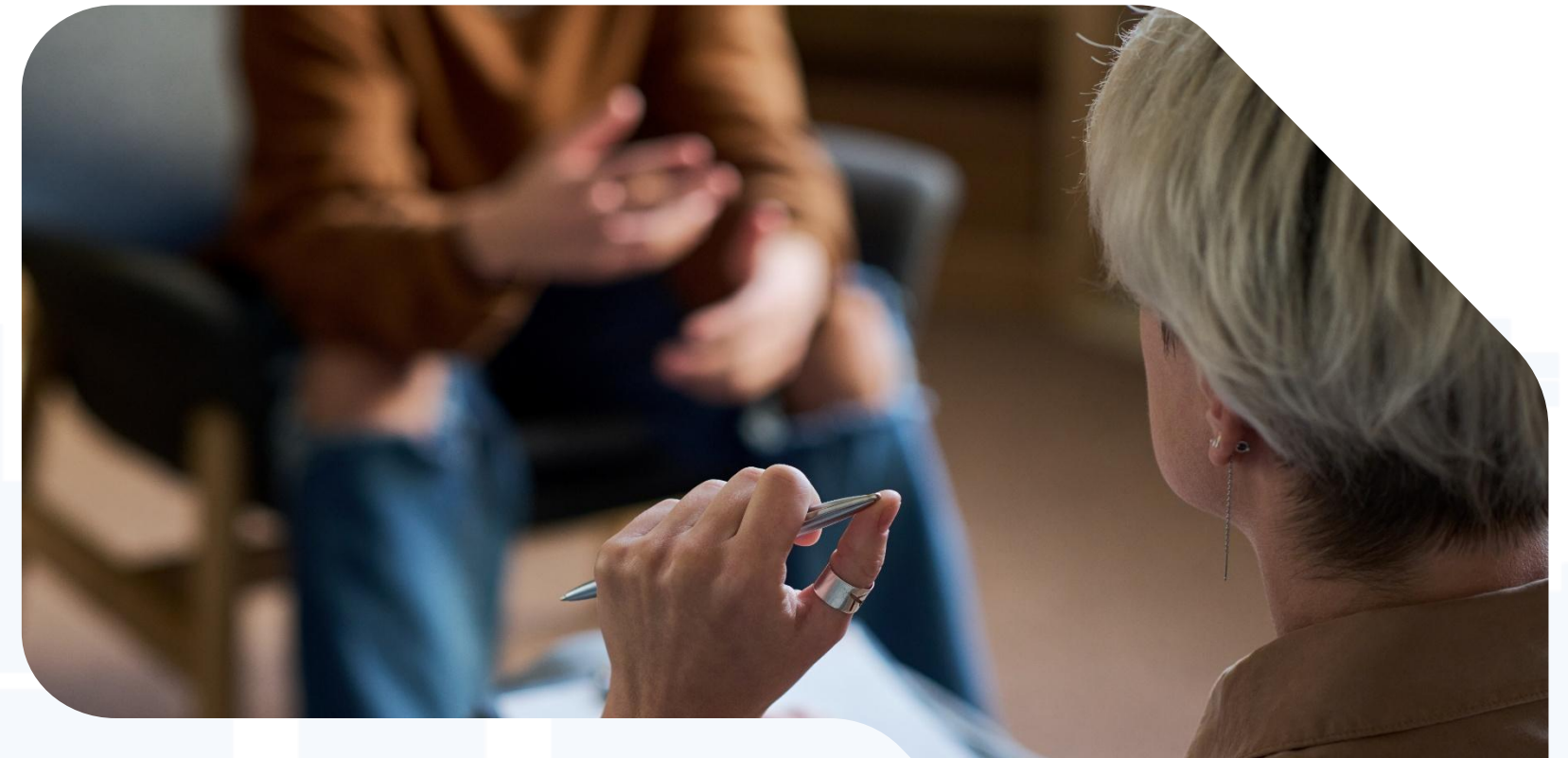


Employee and Supervisor Responsibilities?



➔ All Employees

- Conduct themselves appropriately in the workplace at all times
- May tell another employee their behavior is unwelcome (right, not requirement)
- Fully cooperate in any investigation conducted under AP 10.5.0



➔ What Your Supervisor is Required To Do

Report immediately to HR when they learn of any behavior that may violate this policy:

- Regardless of whether the supervisor thinks it is a violation
- Regardless of whether any employee complained about the behavior
- Regardless of whether an employee wants the report made

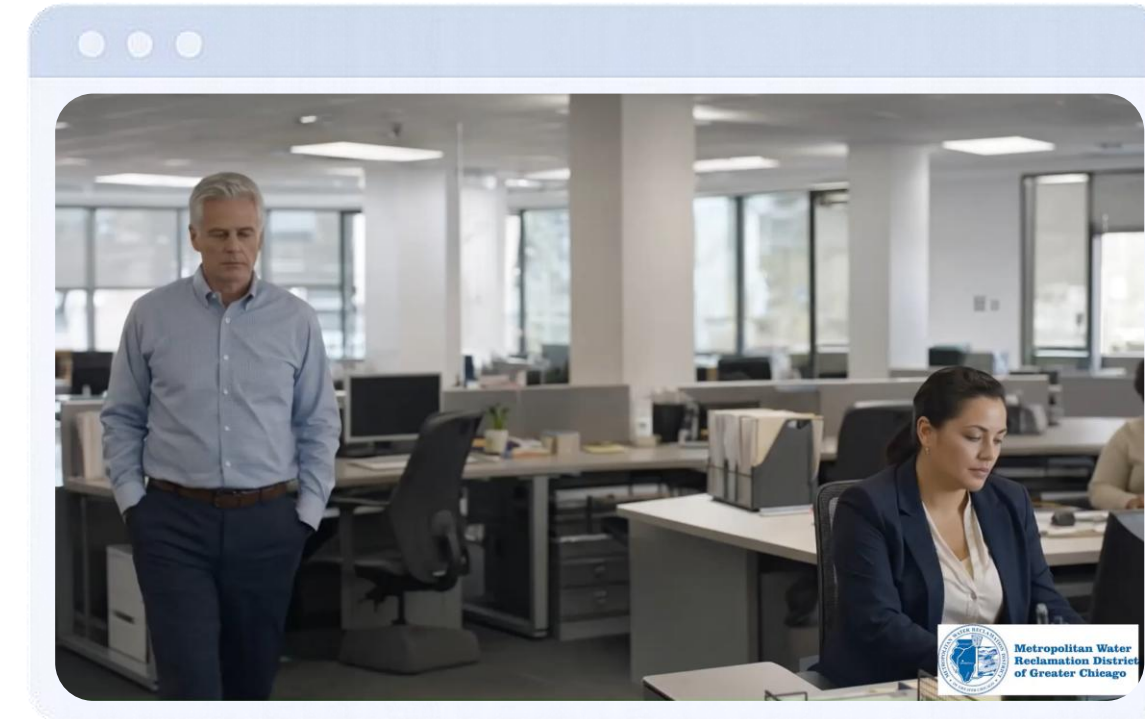
Activity 2

Video Case Study

Watch the video scenario carefully. You will be discussing what you observed in your group immediately after. Pay attention to the behaviors, the responses, and what is not said as much as what is.

Watch for these four things:

- What specific behaviors did you observe?
- What type of conduct did you witness: harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or inappropriate behavior?
- What should Carmen have done in that moment?
- If you were the coworker who witnessed this situation, what actions should you take, and how soon should you take them?



MODULE 2: KEY TAKEAWAYS



- 1 Intent does not determine a violation.**
Impact and reasonableness do. This applies to harassment, discrimination, and retaliation equally.
- 2 All three categories are covered.**
Harassment, discrimination, and retaliation are all prohibited under AP 10.5.0.
- 3 When in doubt, report.**
HR determines whether a violation occurred. Your job is to report the concern.



Module 3

Respectful Workplace, Civility, and Inclusion

Respect Is Not a Feeling. It Is a Behavior.

What it looks like:

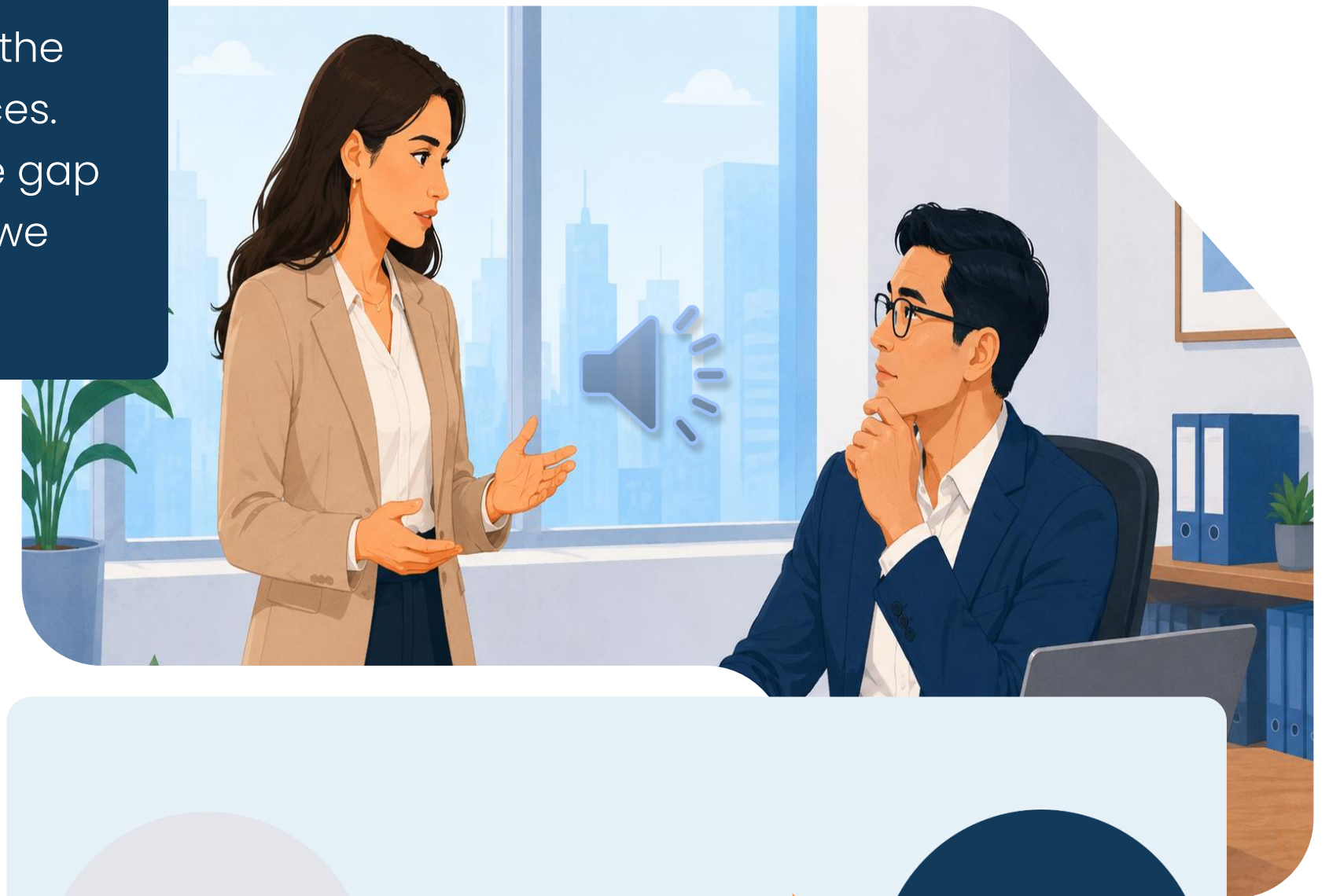
- ✓ Active listening
- ✓ Acknowledging contributions
- ✓ Inclusive language
- ✓ Consistent fair treatment
- ✓ Following through on commitments

What it does not look like:

- ✗ Interrupting or talking over others
- ✗ Dismissing ideas without consideration
- ✗ Exclusionary humor or comments
- ✗ Applying standards inconsistently
- ✗ Saying one thing and doing another

The Behavioral Gap

Most people intend to be respectful. The gap is not in intention. It is in the space between what we meant and what the other person experiences. Behavior is what others observe. Intent stays invisible. What closes the gap is awareness, consistency, and a willingness to course-correct when we miss the mark.



The Spectrum of Workplace Behavior

Workplace behavior exists on a spectrum. At one end, behavior builds trust, safety, and collaboration. At the other, it creates a hostile or legally actionable environment. Most misconduct does not start at the end. It starts in the middle, with behavior that seems small, goes unaddressed, and escalates.



Behaviors that Build/Erodes

Behaviors That Build

- ✓ Listening fully before responding
- ✓ Acknowledging someone's contribution by name
- ✓ Disagreeing directly and professionally
- ✓ Following through on what you say you will do
- ✓ Addressing behavior when it goes wrong
- ✓ Using inclusive language consistently
- ✓ Giving credit where it is due

Behaviors That Erode

- ✗ Interrupting or talking over others
- ✗ Applying standards inconsistently based on who is involved
- ✗ Venting about a coworker to others instead of addressing it directly
- ✗ Staying silent when you witness disrespectful behavior
- ✗ Making jokes at someone's expense and calling it humor
- ✗ Taking credit for someone else's work or idea

"Small things count to the person on the receiving end, when they happen consistently, and in the pattern they establish over time."



Activity 3

Workplace Behavior Spectrum Sort

Your table will receive a set of scenario cards. Each card describes a workplace behavior or situation. As a table, discuss each scenario and sort it into one of the three categories below. Be prepared to explain your reasoning to the group.

		
 APPROPRIATE Professional and consistent with MWRD standards	 INAPPROPRIATE OR UNCIVIL Not professional, but not yet a policy violation	 MUST BE REPORTED Harassment, discrimination, retaliation



Activity 3

Workplace Spectrum Sort-Debrief



Which scenarios were hardest to categorize? Why?



Where did tables disagree with each other?



Which behaviors did you almost put in the wrong category?



What policy would apply to the Must Be Reported cards?



Human Resources Department

312-751-4443



AP 10.5.0

Anti-Harassment,
Anti-Discrimination



AP 10.27.0

Rules for
Employee Conduct

Communication as a Tool for Respect



Interrupting
before someone
finishes



Using sarcasm or
all caps in written
messages



Responding to
concerns with
dismissiveness
or eye rolls



Assuming the worst
interpretation of an
unclear message.



Applying a
different
standard of
patience to
different people

In digital communication (email, text, Teams, Slack), tone is stripped away entirely. What you type and what someone reads are not always the same message.

This vs. That: Communication in Practice

The goal is not to soften difficult messages. It is to communicate with precision and respect at the same time.

WHAT TO AVOID

- ✗ “You’re Wrong.”
- ✗ “That’s not my problem.”
- ✗ “You always do this.”
- ✗ “Obviously...”
- ✗ Replying to all with a complaint

WHAT TO TRY INSTEAD

- ✓ “I see it differently. Here’s why.”
- ✓ “Let me connect you with someone who can help.”
- ✓ “This has come up a few times. Can we talk about it?”
- ✓ Remove “obviously” —it sounds dismissive.
- ✓ Send a direct message to the person involved.



MODULE 3: KEY TAKEAWAYS



1 **Respect is behavioral.**

It is observable, measurable, and a choice. Not a feeling. Not a personality trait, but a daily decision made in every interaction.

2 **Behavior is a spectrum.**

Small things compound. The dangerous zone is not the obvious end. It is the middle, where things get normalized.

3 **Communication is the mechanism.**

How you say something is part of what you say. Tone, timing, and medium all carry meaning, including in digital communication.



BREAK

10 minutes

RETURNING AT

[Facilitator fills in time]

RESTROOMS

[Facilitator confirms]

UP NEXT

Module 4: Complaints, Reporting
& Documentation



Module 4

Complaints, Reporting & Documentation

When to Report

THE THRESHOLD

You do not need to be certain a policy violation occurred before you report. If you experience or witness behavior that **may** violate this policy, you are strongly encouraged to report it immediately.

The threshold for reporting is

CONCERN

Not certainty. Not proof. Not evidence

Human Resources will determine whether a violation occurred. Your job is to report the concern.

REPORT WHEN YOU EXPERIENCE OR WITNESS



Any conduct that may constitute harassment, discrimination, or retaliation



Behavior that makes you or someone else uncomfortable based on a protected characteristic



A supervisor who fails to act on conduct they are aware of



Any adverse change in treatment after a protected activity



Conduct that does not feel right even if you are not sure of the policy category

How to Report: Internal Channels

HR ADMINISTRATION

HR DEPARTMENT

312-751-4443

For harassment, discrimination, retaliation, and workplace conduct concerns



Phone call to 312-751-4443



Walk into HR in person



Send an email or a written letter to HR

OFFICE OF THE INSPECTOR GENERAL

OFFICE OF THE INSPECTOR GENERAL (OIG)

312-751-4444

For improper governmental activity: fraud, corruption, misuse of District property, and related concerns.



Call the OIG 24-hour hotline at 312-751-4444



Schedule an appointment with an OIG Investigator by calling 312-751-4444 or emailing inspectorgeneral@mwrdd.org



Send an email to the OIG at inspectorgeneral@mwrdd.org

Important: Making a false report intentionally is prohibited and subject to discipline. A good-faith report that turns out not to be a violation is not a false report.



How to Report: External Channels

You have the right to file an external complaint **at any time** — including at the same time as making an internal report. You do not need permission. You do not need to exhaust the internal process first.

EXTERNAL AGENCIES FOR COMPLAINT FILING

Illinois Department of Human Rights **IDHR**

State-level discrimination complaints

Equal Employment Opportunity Commission **EEOC**

Federal-level discrimination complaints

Chicago Commission on Human Relations **CCHR**

City of Chicago discrimination complaints

Cook County Commission on Human Rights **CCCHR**

County-level discrimination complaints

IMPORTANT:

Deadlines apply for external filings. Contact each agency directly for its specific procedures and timelines. External complaints may be filed in addition to, or instead of, internal reporting.



The Complaint Process



Step 1

Written complaint submitted through the appropriate chain of command

The employee submits a written complaint within 7 calendar days of learning of the event.

The supervisor responds in writing within 7 calendar days.

Step 2

Appeal to Department Head

If unresolved, the employee may appeal in writing to the Department Head within 7 calendar days.

The Department Head responds in writing within 7 calendar days.

Step 3

Appeal to HR Director

If the issue remains unresolved, the employee may appeal in writing to the Director of Human Resources within 7 calendar days. HR investigates and responds in writing.

Optional

Civil Service Board

Under Personnel Rule 12.01, there may be an optional final appeal to the Civil Service Board.

WHO THIS PROCESS APPLIES TO

AP 10.15.0 outlines the formal complaint procedure for **non-represented employees** addressing employment-related concerns through a chain-of-command process.

Represented employees should refer to their applicable **Collective Bargaining Agreement (CBA)** for grievance procedures.

This process may include concerns involving **immediate supervisors**, including employment-related decisions or actions.





AP 10.5.0 — Sections B.3 and C

Confidentiality and Non-Retaliation Protections

Your report will be kept confidential to the greatest extent possible. HR will not broadcast who filed a complaint.

Important limitation: If HR needs to share information to conduct a thorough investigation, they may do so. There is no guarantee of complete privacy, but there is a commitment to limiting disclosure to what the investigation requires.

If You Experience Retaliation After Reporting

- 1 **Document** the adverse change — date, what happened, who was present
- 2 **Report it separately** to HR immediately. Do not wait to see if it gets better.
- 3 **Let HR make the connection.** Your job is to report the pattern, not to prove it.

"Silence in the face of retaliation is not self-protection. It is the opposite."



Activity 4

What Would You Say?

Review the scenario in your participant guide.

At your table:

- Assign roles: Reporter, Responder, Observer
- Act out the conversation

Your goal is not to “solve” the situation but to practice how to respond in the moment.

Roles

- 1 **Reporter:** Share your concern and uncertainty with your colleague (Responder).
- 2 **Responder:** Listen, support, and help identify next steps.
- 3 **Observer:** Watch for what helps and what doesn't.



After Role Play.....

Debrief at your table for 3 minutes, then share out.



MODULE 5: KEY TAKEAWAYS



1

Concern is the threshold

You do not need proof to report. HR determines whether a violation occurred. Your job is to report the concern.

2

Know which process applies.

AP 10.5.0 for harassment, discrimination, and retaliation. AP 10.15.0 for other workplace concerns. When in doubt, call HR.

3

Know the numbers.

312-751-4443
HR Department

312-751-4444
Office of the Inspector General (OIG)

EXTERNAL AGENCIES AVAILABLE

IDHR | EEOC | Chicago Commission on Human Relations
| Cook County Commission on Human Rights



Module 5

Reflection

MY REFLECTION



- 1** One thing I learned today that I did not know before.
- 2** One thing I will do differently starting this week.
- 3** One way I will contribute to a respectful workplace on my team or crew.

Take **3 minutes** to complete your Reflection Card. This is personal, and you will not be asked to share it.

Metropolitan Water Reclamation District of Greater Chicago



Thank You For Your Attention and Participation

Every employee who completes this training, takes it seriously, and carries it back to their team makes MWRD stronger, safer, and more equitable.

www.mwrd.org



HR Department
312-751-4443



OIG
312-751-4444

